

“Open source networking solutions accelerate innovation”



Developed by Microsoft and its community partners eight years ago, SONiC claims to be the first open source networking software to run on multiple switches, with participation from several silicon chip vendors and hardware manufacturers. In an exclusive conversation, **Ashay Krishna**, Director Of Engineering, Microsoft, explains to *OSFY's Yashasvini Razdan* why organisations should adopt open source networking solutions, and the role the community plays in their adoption and growth.

Ashay Krishna,
Director Of Engineering, Microsoft

Q. What are the industry trends driving demand for open source networking solutions?

A. Several trends are influencing this demand. First, organisations do not want to be locked into a single hardware vendor or silicon manufacturer. Flexibility to explore alternatives is a significant driver.

Second, financial considerations play a crucial role. While hardware can often be relatively inexpensive, the services bundled with it tend to be very costly. Open source networking solutions eliminate service costs, allowing organisations to set up and manage their networks with smaller teams. This can reduce overall costs by 50–60%.

Q. How has the market perception towards SONiC evolved over the years?

A. The market has been great. SONiC began as a research project, with only a small group of individuals experimenting in a closely-knit community. Today, there are over 40 major contributors including some of the largest OEMs and hyperscalers, more than 400 consumers across many industries, and thousands of developers actively involved in SONiC's growth. The market has been growing steadily, and the solution has been widely adopted.

Q. When speaking to your customers, who is the ideal first point of discussion—the development team, IT infrastructure management, or the purchasing department?

A. Two key stakeholders to engage with are the Chief Technology Officer (CTO) or the head of the technical department, and the purchasing team.

The former can assess the value SONiC brings and understand the challenges and benefits of transitioning from legacy systems, while the purchasing team significantly reduces overall costs, making the financial perspective critical.

These two roles are essential in ensuring a smooth discussion and decision-making process.

Q. How do open source networking solutions such as SONiC compare with other proprietary software?

A. Traditional networking software from incumbents, large and small, often have drawbacks. Feature updates are slow, contributions are limited to a restricted group, and there is heavy dependence on specific hardware vendors. With open source networking solutions, the entire community can